

Immigration and Urbanization**Lesson 1**

The New Immigrants

Key Terms and People

Ellis Island Inspection station for immigrants arriving on the East Coast

Angel Island Inspection station for immigrants arriving on the West Coast

melting pot A mixture of different cultures and races who blended together

nativism Obvious favoritism toward native-born Americans

Chinese Exclusion Act Act that limited Chinese immigration

Gentlemen's Agreement Agreement in which Japan agreed to limit unskilled workers from emigrating to the U.S. if U.S. repealed the San Francisco segregation order

Before You Read

In the last lesson you read about the nation's labor movement. In this lesson you will read about the immigrants who entered the U.S., how their lives changed, and how they affected the U.S.

As You Read

Use a chart to take notes on where immigrants came from, why they came, where they entered the U.S., and the differences between immigrants and native-born Americans.

THROUGH THE "GOLDEN DOOR"**Where did the immigrants come from?**

Between 1870 and 1920 about 20 million Europeans immigrated to the United States. Many of them came from eastern and southern European countries such as Germany, Italy, Poland, and Russia.

Some immigrants came to escape religious persecution. Others left because of rising populations and to overcome poverty and improve their economic situation. Still others came to experience greater freedom in the United States.

A smaller number of immigrants came from Asia. About 200,000 Chinese

immigrants came from 1851 to 1883. They came to get rich during the gold rush. Many Chinese immigrants helped build the nation's first transcontinental railroad. When the United States annexed Hawaii in 1898, several thousand Japanese immigrants came to the United States.

From 1880 to 1920 about 260,000 immigrants arrived from various islands in the Caribbean Sea. They came from Jamaica, Cuba, Puerto Rico, and other islands. Many left their homelands because jobs were scarce.

Many Mexicans came to the United States as well. Some became U.S. citizens when the nation acquired

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Mexican territory in 1848 as a result of the Mexican War. About 700,000 Mexicans arrived from 1910 to 1930 to escape turmoil in their country.

1. Name two regions of the world where immigrants to the United States came from.

A DIFFICULT JOURNEY; LIFE IN THE NEW LAND

How did immigrants cope in America?

Many immigrants traveled to the United States by steamship. On board the ship, they shared a cramped, unsanitary space. Under these harsh conditions, disease spread quickly. As a result, some immigrants died before they reached America.

Most European immigrants to the United States arrived in New York. There, they had to pass through an immigration station located on **Ellis Island** in New York harbor. Officials at the station decided whether the immigrants could enter the country or had to return. Any immigrant with serious health problems or a contagious disease was sent home. Inspectors also made sure that immigrants met the legal requirements for entering the United States.

Asian immigrants arriving on the West Coast went through **Angel Island** in San Francisco. The inspection process on Angel Island was more difficult than on Ellis Island. Other immigrants, from the West Indies and Mexico, arrived in the eastern, southeastern, and western U.S.

Getting along in a new country with a different language and culture was a great challenge for new immigrants.

Many immigrants settled in communities with other immigrants from the same country. This made them feel more at home, and they could practice their customs and speak their native language. These ethnic neighborhoods provided support and a connection. People built churches or synagogues, ate ethnic foods, and set up businesses. Immigrants also wanted to fit in, but native-born people often disliked immigrants' customs and languages.

2. Name two ways immigrants dealt with adjusting to life in the United States.

IMMIGRATION RESTRICTIONS

How did some Americans react to immigration?

By the turn of the century, some people thought of America as a **melting pot**. This term described the blending together of different cultures and races by giving up their native languages and customs.

However, many new immigrants refused to give up their culture and language. This led some Americans to have strong feelings against immigrants. Also, since many Americans were Protestants, they resented that some immigrants were Catholic or Jewish. These feelings led to **nativism**, an obvious preference for native-born Americans. Nativism gave rise to anti-immigrant groups and a demand for immigration restrictions.

On the West Coast, prejudice against Asians was first directed at the Chinese. During the 1870s depression, many Chinese immigrants worked for low

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wages. American workers feared they would lose their jobs. As a result, labor groups pressured politicians to restrict Asian immigration. In 1882 Congress passed the **Chinese Exclusion Act**, which banned all but a few Chinese immigrants. The ban was not lifted until 1943.

Americans showed prejudice against Japanese immigrants, too. In San Francisco, the local school board put all Asian children in separate schools. Japan protested the action. President

Theodore Roosevelt persuaded San Francisco officials to stop their separation policy. Then, Japan agreed to limit emigration of unskilled workers to the United States under the **Gentlemen's Agreement** of 1907–1908.

3. Give two examples of anti-immigration measures in the U.S.

Answer the questions about immigration in the United States during the late 19th and early 20th centuries. In the fourth column, mark an X in each box that applies.

Immigrants from . . .	From where did immigrants come?	What reasons did they often have for coming to the U.S.?	Where did they often enter the U.S.?
1. Southern and Eastern Europe			☐ Ellis Island ☐ Angel Island ☐ Southeastern U.S. ☐ Southwestern U.S.
2. Asia			☐ Ellis Island ☐ Angel Island ☐ Southeastern U.S. ☐ Southwestern U.S.
3. West Indies and Mexico			☐ Eastern U.S. ☐ Angel Island ☐ Southeastern U.S. ☐ Western U.S.
What was an important difference between native-born Americans and some or all of the new immigrants?			
4. Native-Born Americans		5. New Immigrants	